

ANI



CASH FLOW Left, Chatterjee with Arpita; top, stacks of cash recovered

THE MODUS OPERANDI

- Touts contacted applicants, offered primary teacher's job for **Rs 8-10 lakh each**; secondary & higher secondary teacher's job for **Rs 10-12 lakh each**
- Names then pushed to Chatterjee's close circle, recommendations made. On the basis of their recommendations, RTIs were made to fetch answer scripts.
- Marked increase in answer scripts of recommended candidates, their names are published, **pushing deserving candidates** way down the list
- **Documents related to the appointment of Group C, D staff,** admit cards of candidates, summary of final results found in Chatterjee's residence

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be taken against anyone proven guilty. Clearly, the script was Abhishek's. Mamata broke her silence on the issue only after 48 hours. "If someone is proved guilty in a trial, I wouldn't mind him getting life imprisonment, but...if they (BJP) think they can break my party and my government by using central agencies, I will not let that happen. Tell me where nepotism doesn't happen?" she said on July 25.

Other aspects of the case have also embarrassed the party. According to ED sources, Arpita alone has 39 properties, including flats, resorts and farm houses in Shantiniketan. It is now being widely alleged that after his wife died in July 2017, Chatterjee's visits to Arpita's 2,000 sq. ft south Kolkata flat became frequent. On the money trail, the ED is said to have found six shell companies and a link in Bangladesh for parking crores of money. There's another woman from the academic world whose alleged proximity with Chatterjee and disproportionate assets are also under the scanner.

Even though the party is yet to divest Chatterjee of his portfolios—commerce and industry, IT and parliamentary affairs and the post of secretary general of TMC—a cabinet meeting is likely to take a call on his ouster. In December 2014 when Madan Mitra was arrested for being involved in the Saradha scam, his portfolios were taken away. Chatterjee is said to have returned the official car he was using. Even though party veterans were reluctant to write his political epitaph, pressure is mounting on Mamata, as the scam, as per the ED's estimation, could ultimately cross Rs 300 crore.

Another person under the scanner is TMC MLA Manik Bhattacharya, a former president of the state board of primary education, who is suspected to have played a role in the irregularities in appointments. The ED has claimed to have recovered some documents related to the alleged scam from his house, and he's now being questioned.

"The party line is to wait for the court verdict and go for a blackout to uphold the image of the party. It will be easier then to reason that on issues of corruption TMC is uncompromising," says a veteran TMC leader.

"Corruption has never been an issue in Bengal. The Narada scam was out during the 2016 polls, yet Mamata won a majority and the accused leaders won handsomely. Bengal politics goes by identity. The 30 per cent Muslim vote will not desert Mamata, and if you add the beneficiary votes, she will continue to have the bulk support," says political analyst Biswanath Chakrabarty. For all the protestations of the BJP about bringing the TMC government to its knees with more exposes, Mamata is nearly invincible on her home turf. ■